



OCHA

Coordination Saves Lives

United Nations Office
for the Coordination of
Humanitarian Affairs

Doing More With More OCHA's Cooperation with the Volunteer Technical Community

During a UN [staff meeting in early January 2011](#), the Secretary General told staff that we need to “learn to do more with what we have” and encouraged us to be creative and take initiative. At the same time he also said that he would be “generous or tolerant” if employees made mistakes when trying to do their job better. The OCHA Information Management (IM) team, part of the Communication and Information Services Branch, accepted this challenge and has recently taken a huge step in working with the Volunteer Technical Community (VTC), a group of independent people in many countries willing and able to help in processing, validating and mapping the flood of reports from crises. In addition OCHA has made use of the virtual resources of OCHA IM staff in remote duty stations to aid in the humanitarian response to crises in Libya and Japan.

While responding in 2010 to the devastating earthquake in Haiti and the massive flooding in Pakistan, OCHA's IM team realized that the VTCs and remote OCHA IM staff could play a significant role in aiding in-country information management teams responding to a humanitarian crisis. However, at the time we did not know how to leverage their true potential to sift through available online data and continuous social media and mobile updates from the field. In late 2010, a volunteer coordination body called the [Standby Task Force](#) was initiated and the [Harvard Humanitarian Initiative](#), with support from the [UN Foundation](#), drafted the [Disaster Relief 2.0 report](#) on the interplay between traditional humanitarian actors and groups such as the VTC (to be launched at [DIHAD](#) next week). In February 2011, the [IASC Information Management Task Force](#), composed of major humanitarian responders, met to discuss how to best engage the volunteer community. These three initiatives gave OCHA a much better understanding of how we could utilize the VTCs and manage remote IM operations.

Social Media and News Mapping

On 1 March 2011, a day the OCHA's IM team will remember for quite some time, we took a giant leap forward; **We wanted to do “more with less”**. At short notice, we organized a teleconference with [UNOSAT](#), [NetHope](#) and the major VTC bodies - [Crisis Mappers](#), [Crisis Commons](#), [Harvard Humanitarian Initiative](#), [Open Street Map](#), and [Google's Crisis Response Team](#) – most of which are emerging actors in the humanitarian arena. During that meeting, OCHA requested the activation of the [Standby Task Force](#) to monitor news and social media to better understand what was happening inside Libya, given that the UN could not deploy staff on the ground. As a result, the [LibyaCrisisMap.net](#) website was launched and supported by over [200 volunteers from around the world](#) (see map on page 2 for locations of the volunteers).

As the humanitarian situation deteriorated, we realized that we needed to rotate volunteers to keep the site running (the initial volunteers were scheduled to assist for two weeks). Reaching out to [UNV](#), we leveraged their [Online Volunteering program](#), and within 72 hours we had over 300 applicants to help out.



How successful has the website been? After launching a public version, which removed any information that could identify individuals or groups, we had over 17,000 unique visitors in the first 72 hours alone. The private site, which includes all details, is being used by WFP, UNHCR, UNOSAT, the Red Cross and many other verified organizations to perform certain type of analysis and to aid in their planning. The WFP's Executive Director, Josette Sheeran, was so excited with the site that [she took to Twitter to highlight its importance](#).

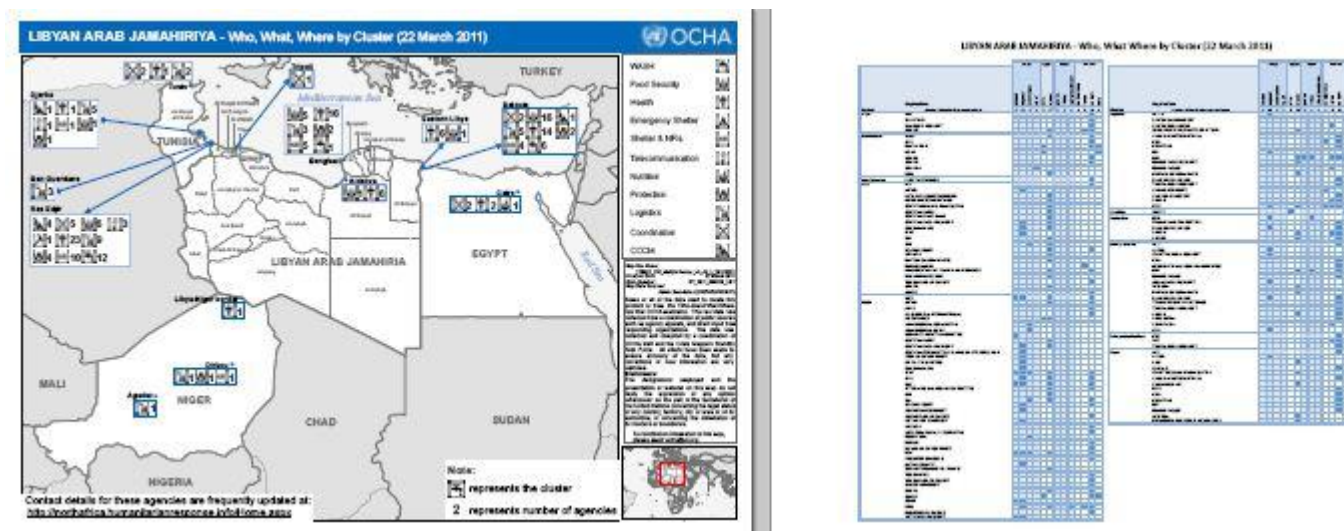


OCHA switches on its own remote IM support

Another lesson learned over the past few emergencies is the possibility of leveraging ICT to enable remote IM support to an emergency. In no way does it replace the need for staff on the ground, but it can augment and improve what can be done. So, for Libya, OCHA put out a call to the OCHA Information Management Officers around the world to see if they could help. After all, they truly understood the IM needs during an emergency. As a result, we have staff aiding the response remotely from countries such as Pakistan, Kenya, South Africa, Ethiopia, and Colombia. They were especially helpful in identifying who was responding to the crisis. In OCHA, this is called the “3W”

Who is doing What Where (3W)

One key product that can help in the coordination of a humanitarian response is Who-is-doing-What-Where (3W). In most new emergencies, collecting and compiling the information about all of the organizations operating can be a huge challenge. In Haiti, we knew about 1200+ new organizations had arrived in just the first two weeks. For Libya, we decided to try a new approach: using both the volunteers and the remote OCHA IM staff. Leveraging the freely available [Google Docs platform](#), we had 3W information arriving within a couple hours. The volunteers scoured through Internet sources, OCHA staff then verified the information, and OCHA Pakistan created the [3W Maps](#).



Baseline Indicators

As outlined in the [IASC Operational Guidance for Coordinated Assessments in Humanitarian Crises](#), working from a core set of indicators is an important aspect to ensure an optimized humanitarian response. But, without staff in the country, how are we to find the nation-wide baseline humanitarian indicators? Again, we turned to the volunteer community. OCHA setup a list of indicators to source and gave the team two days. After closing the task, OCHA quickly verified the data found, placed the content into an easily legible format, and shared with the responding clusters/sectors. The result is a [Baseline Humanitarian Indicators for Libya](#).

Common Operational Dataset for Japan

We all know about the devastating earthquake and tsunami that affected Japan on 11 March 2011. Although the Japanese government has requested limited assistance from the UN, OCHA recognized that compiling the [Common Operational Datasets](#) for Japan may provide a valuable service to any national or international responding agency. In this instance, we turned to [CrisisCommons](#) in hopes that they could help. Their volunteers did an amazing job compiling a [Japan Data Profile](#) wiki of various data sources available in the public. One volunteer even burnt out his own computer by automating so many Google queries. They were a dedicated group. The compiled data was used by [MapAction responders](#) (who were supporting [UNDAC](#)), [NetHope](#) partners, and others providing relief. In Crisis Commons's recent blog post about their experience, they note that they "have recommended the review of the ISAC Common

Operational Dataset Guidance to [the US government’s] FEMA’s Situational Assessment Planning team for the upcoming National Level Exercise”. I would say that this is a great example of how we can share and learn from a wide variety of actors if we are open to do so.

But what about the future and sustainability?

OCHA’s HQ-based IM team focused on trying to make this model - using volunteers and remote UN staff - work. It was our first time and there were challenges. We learned a lot of lessons. But we believe that it is the way of the future and have already had discussions with many of our partners, including those in the [IASC IM Task Force](#), on how to take it forward. We are planning a review meeting with the volunteers .

The major challenge that OCHA will face is if we are going to leverage the volunteers and remote support for every humanitarian emergency, we may need to augment our HQ-based IM team. In the Libya instance, a vast majority of the team was focused on supporting these tasks. This meant that our other work was shelved for a month, staff often worked long hours and weekends. Of course this is our job, but this was for just one emergency.

There are over 30 humanitarian emergencies each year that require OCHA to *mobilize and coordinate effective and principled humanitarian action* in order to alleviate human suffering. If the humanitarian community is going to take advantage of the enormous opportunities presented through the use of virtual volunteers, we will need to keep looking for ways to allow us all “to do more”.

More information

If you would like more information about OCHA’s experience leveraging the volunteer technical community and coordinating report IM support during an emergency, feel free to contact Brendan McDonald [mcdonaldb@un.org] and Andrej Verity [verity@un.org].

On behalf of OCHA’s Information Management Team and the volunteers worldwide,

Brendan McDonald
Chief, Information Services Section
Communications and Information Services
Branch (CISB)/OCHA

Tel: +41229172810
Email: mcdonaldb@un.org

<http://ochaonline.un.org>
<http://www.reliefweb.int>
<http://www.irinnews.org>

Andrej Verity
Information Management Officer
Information Services Section (ISS)
Communications and Information Services
Branch (CISB)/OCHA

Tel: +41-22-917-1938
Email: verity@un.org